HOSPITALITY

TREND





The cigar Lounge at Arq, the Leela Palace New Delhi's member's-only club; The Stefano Ricci meeting room at The Taj Mahal, New Delhi

There is a moment—usually unremarkable to anyone watching—when you walk through a door and feel, instinctively, that you belong. Not because someone has told you so. Not because your name is on a list. But because the people in the room, the art on the walls, the quiet ritual of a well-poured glass—all of it says: you are among your own. This is the promise of the private members club. And right now, that promise is being made with extraordinary urgency and ambition across India. Above all else, the great private club is not a venue; it is a frequency. And India is only just beginning to tune in.

ORIGINS: FROM GENTLEMAN'S LONDON TO THE BENGAL CLUB

The private members club is, at its heart, a British invention—though one, the British themselves inherited from the coffeehouses of 17th-century London, where merchants, writers and politicians gathered to trade gossip, credit and ideas in equal measure. By the 18th century, these informal nodes had crystallised into formal institutions: White's (1693), the oldest surviving gentlemen's club, on St James's Street; the Reform Club, where Liberal parliamentarians debated empire over claret; and later, Annabel's—opened in 1963 in a Mayfair basement—which became one of the most glamorous private clubs in the world, hosting royalty and Hollywood celebrities alike.

The British brought this culture to India with colonial efficiency. In 1827, The Bengal Club was established in Calcutta—the so-called unofficial headquarters of the British Raj—followed by a proliferation of gymkhanas, yacht clubs and racing clubs across Bombay, Delhi and Madras. These were instruments of social sorting: they told you who mattered and, crucially, who did not. Membership was hereditary, hierarchical and almost

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